

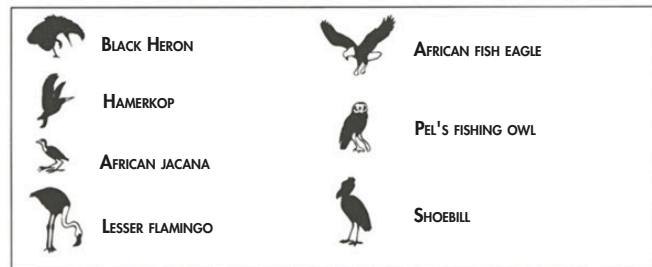
Rivers, Lakes, and Swamps



AFRICA'S FRESHWATER HABITATS include great rivers such as the Nile and the Niger as well as vast swamps such as the Sudd and the Okavango Delta. These swamps, and the marshes that surround the great rivers, teem with life, especially fish. Large numbers of fish-eating birds live there, including herons, egrets, ibises, storks, and pelicans. Reeds

and rafts of lilies growing in the warm, shallow waters also provide nest sites and safe places to feed.

In the east of Africa lies the long, narrow Great Rift Valley. It has formed where a section of Earth's crust is slowly splitting, causing the land in between to sink. On the flat valley floor are many spectacular lakes. Birds from Europe and Asia use African lakes and swamps as resting places when they migrate across the continent.



African fish eagle
(*Haliaeetus vocifer*)
Length: 2 ft 6½ in (75 cm)

Courting males and females show off their flying skills—they try to grab each other's talons as they tumble downward through the air.

African fish eagle

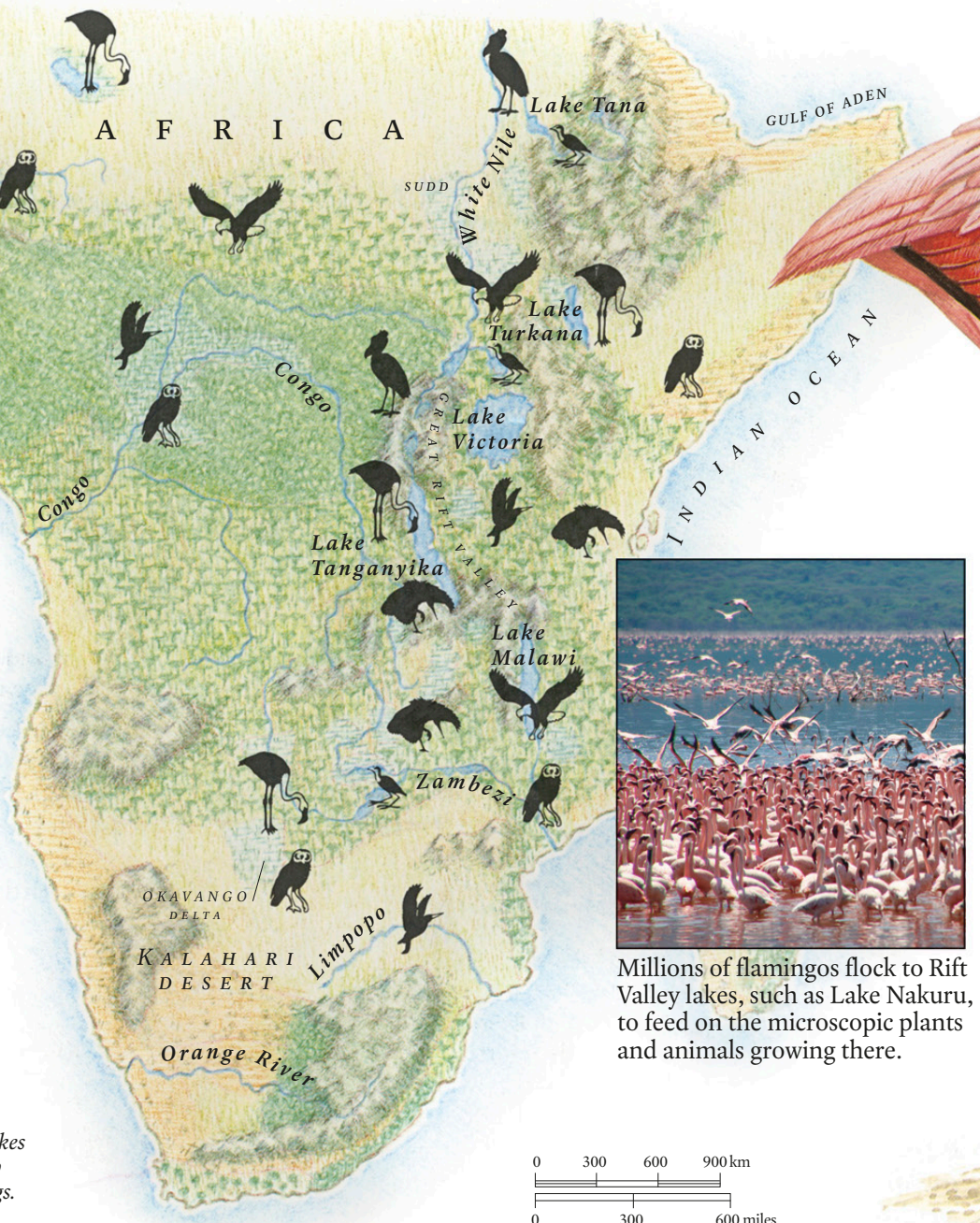
This bird spends much of its time perched in tall trees near water. From time to time, it swoops down to snatch fish from the surface in its powerful claws. Sometimes it plunges underwater feet first and then rises up, lifting the fish clear out of the water.

Pel's fishing owl
(*Scotopelia peli*)
Length: 2 ft (61 cm)

Large eyes help the owl to see well in the dark.

Pel's fishing owl
During the day, Pel's fishing owl hides away in trees near rivers and swamps. At night, it swoops low over the water and catches fish in its powerful feet. Its legs and feet are bare so it has no feathers that could trail in the water. Unlike other owls, fishing owls do not have fringed feathers and soft plumage for silent flight as they do not need to fly quietly to sneak up on fish.

Feet have small spikes underneath to grip slippery fish or frogs.



Millions of flamingos flock to Rift Valley lakes, such as Lake Nakuru, to feed on the microscopic plants and animals growing there.